

THE NET RESULTS

Like Reds, Tennis People Should Have Fun and Try Hard

By MARGARET OSBORNE duPONT

SUPER SPORTSMAN SPARKY ANDERSON, manager of the Cincinnati Reds baseball team, in describing how the Reds reached the World Series, said simply, "We had fun while we won." Would that more young tennis players, too, would have fun while playing tennis, and if they did, chances



are they'll win more. Unfortunately, today it seems to me that parents place too much emphasis on winning without first encouraging their children to develop the techniques of winning, and one of those techniques is enjoying — having fun — doing what they're doing. Young tennis players should enjoy playing the game. Tennis is a great game, a sport for a lifetime, which one should thoroughly enjoy. Don't mistake me, I'm not saying winning is not important. Indeed it is, in competitive sports and club

Mrs. duPONT matches alike, but the emphasis, especially for all young players, should be on trying, not just winning. After all, chances are if you try hard enough, concentrate and work hard enough, you will win. Showing even the slightest bit of displeasure on the tennis court serves only to disrupt your concentration and give your opponent more confidence. A suggestion for parents of all young tennis players: Make an effort to see that your children have fun while trying hard.

"Keep the ball in front of you," advised those Baltimore and Cincinnati home run hitters. So too in tennis, for control, power and good timing, step out and meet the ball. Avoid letting it 'ride you' or get behind you, but rather keep the ball out in front of you. How far out in front depends a lot on what direction you plan to hit the ball. For instance, crosscourt shots must be hit further out in front of you (in order to follow through in the direction of the flight of the ball) than a straight-away, down-the-line shot, which is sometimes hit 'off the hip'. Volleying errors are often caused by letting the ball get behind you. Remember, the closer you are to the net the less time you have to prepare for your stroke, so the shorter your backswing should be. Actually, some volleys are made simply by letting the ball hit the racket — in other words, 'blocking' the ball — with a firm grip, of course.

Keep the Ball Out in Front

IT'S IMPORTANT FOR the service toss to be ahead (between you and the net) of you. Ideally, if you let the tossed ball drop it will land about a foot ahead, or in front, of your left foot (if you're right-handed, and vice versa). Nor can too much be said about keeping the ball in front of you while executing the overhead smash. Pointing up at the ball with your left arm extended can help you keep your eye on the ball and your body in the best position, thereby keeping the ball in the correct flight pattern for you to hit it out in front of you. If you let the lob get the least little bit behind you, you will not be able to follow through correctly for a hard-hit, smashing placement! Also, the sooner you hit the ball, the less time your opponent will have to prepare for his next return.

While watching the World Series did you notice how the batters kept their heads still, eyes intent on the oncoming ball from the moment the pitcher started his wind-up? You golfers know how important it is to not move your head in the middle of a swing. 'Tis true in tennis, too. It helps keep your eye on the ball, the first rule of tennis, and stabilizes your body movements.

Concentration . . . Quiet Pleasure

ON THE PRE-GAME TV 'HOT LINE' program, Andy Cohen (I believe) said of the Reds' only winning pitcher, Clay Carroll, "Determination and concentration are written all over his face." You know Carroll wasn't thinking about attendance figures, who was in the crowd, umpires, names and positions, etc. Next time you attend a tennis tournament or go to the courts, notice how many participants are concentrating only on their own matches, or are their eyes wandering around to see what's happening on the court next to them, to see who and how many spectators there are, etc? Chances are the winners-to-be will be thinking about what they, and they alone, are doing. Some people say concentration is 90 per cent of the game — you know it's important. Determination and concentration written all over one's face does not mean one is not enjoying the game. For many people true enjoyment is not hilarity, but rather quiet pleasure playing the game.

There were some rather large football-type players (Oriole Boog Powell, for example) on both teams, but one of the top performers was the Reds' little centerfielder, Bobby Tolan. Why? According to his manager it's because "he gives 100 to 110 per cent effort all the time". He never took it easy for a minute; he was trying hard all the time, and so should tennis players. Even when you're ahead 30-0 or 40-15 in a game, or have a large game lead in a set, you should strive to win every point. Some players unconsciously let-down when they're ahead; they don't really intend to — they just do! You can avoid letting-down by concentrating hard on the very next point, giving 110 per cent of yourself all the time, too. Remember, 4-1 and 5-2 game scores are often only a one-service break lead, and the minute you drop your serve the score is the same as all tied-up and you 'big lead' has vanished.